recent developments like the bridge building across Pangong Tso and establishment of border villages take place in areas whose control passed into their hands 60 years ago. And the infrastructure neglect till 2014 compounded this predicament.

India, therefore, needs to factor in these legacy complications while refashioning a response for a more difficult era. Some of that is to step up its efforts on the ground, some to explore effective technology options. Given the manifest commitment to defend its interests, an optimal combination will always emerge to be continually refreshed. All of that has come into sharper focus for a government that is fully seized of the magnitude of the challenges before it.

The second issue is that of comprehensive national power. Naturally, there are outcomes that reflect the lack of purpose on the Indian side till 2014. Technology and tactics can offer some compensations on their own score. India is, therefore, compelled to imaginatively address the problem of dealing with a powerful adversary. Policymakers of the past may shirk their responsibility, but the record is there for all of us to see. Indeed, we have already noted a radical shift in the positioning of many who advocated a very different outlook in office.

The sensible response, of course, is to build deep strengths as rapidly as possible, where necessary, in partnership with others. The current geopolitical scenario offers more possibilities in this respect. But there must be both the full awareness and the greater determination to exploit such opportunities. Nothing is more important than securing our borders.

There are even larger developments pertaining to India’s status that feed into the problems of our times. We are all aware how much Partition diminished our strategic stature. But what it also did was create the basis for a subcontinental balance of power. And even worse, the incomplete exercise of sovereignty in Jammu & Kashmir in 1948 allowed a physical contiguity that is now a matter of deep concern. Ideological blinkers were responsible for the wilful neglect of the first principles of international relations in the past. Even open Sino-Pakistan collaboration since 1963 has consistently been underestimated, failing to prepare us for what was to come next. When the CPEC was unveiled as part of the BRI, its forthright rejection by India was second-guessed publicly by some in the country. Excuses were advanced and workarounds sought to be invented, all the while ignoring a clear message from China.